NATURE-BASED SOCIAL-EMOTIONAL LEARNING (SEL) PROGRAMMME

PILOT WORKSHOP REPORT

NATURE CLASSROOMS

(July 8th 2023 to August 31st 2023)

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. Shifting Approaches in Environmental Education

An increasingly prominent approach in environmental education involves integrating the affective domain of learning, which aims to emotionally engage learners by addressing their attitudes, beliefs and feelings. This shift in approach can prove invaluable when tackling environmental problems, considering that many barriers to improving environmental equality are rooted in prevailing social attitudes, values and lifestyles. Moreover, research demonstrates that environmental changes can also affect psychological and mental health outcomes.

The Social-Emotional Learning (SEL) framework is one such model that allows for the integration of the affective domain in teaching-learning spaces. As described by the Collaborative for Academic, Social and Emotional Learning (CASEL), *'social-emotional learning is the process by which all young people and adults acquire knowledge, skills, and attitudes to develop healthy identities, manage emotions and achieve personal and collective goals, feel and show empathy for others, establish and maintain supportive relationships and make responsible and caring decisions.'*

A) Five Core Components of SEL

- **Self-Awareness:** the ability to understand one's own emotions, thoughts, and values and how they influence behaviour across contexts.
- **Self-Management**: the ability to manage one's emotions, thoughts, and behaviours effectively in different situations and to achieve goals and aspirations.
- **Social Awareness**: the ability to understand the perspectives of and empathise with others, including those from diverse backgrounds, cultures, and contexts.
- **Relationship Skills**: the ability to establish and maintain healthy and supportive relationships and to effectively navigate settings with diverse individuals and groups.
- **Responsible Decision Making**: the ability to make caring and constructive choices about personal behaviour and social interactions across diverse situations

1.2. Nature Classrooms Nature-Based SEL Initiative

Schools are often perceived as spaces for teaching and learning. But they are far more complex, intricate, and emotional by nature. They are spaces of dynamic interpersonal, intrapersonal, and interbeing interactions, which require high levels of social and emotional investment from all its members.

Teachers, in particular, play a pivotal role in this web of interactions, as they engage with not just the diverse set of students within their classrooms, but also with their peers and other school staff. As they develop lesson plans and strategies to educate their students, they are often confronted with challenges that require them to address many of the social, emotional, and nature-related concepts, which go beyond the bounds of the textbooks and curriculums. And finally, stepping outside their classroom, they are also faced with administrative, social, and personal responsibilities that add to the complexity of their social and emotional state. All of which could reflect in their interactions within the classroom.

With this programme, our goal is to put together effective practices, resources, and frameworks integrated with social, emotional, and nature–based learning at its core, with a focus on supporting the overall well-being of teachers. The long-term vision is that this social and emotional development within teachers also influences the manner in which they impart nature education within their classrooms.

Through this programme we are keen on exploring:

- Can nature-based practices and engagements support in promoting social and emotional well-being of teachers?
- How does supporting teachers' emotional state influence their connections with nature?
- How does this process of engaging with nature-based social-emotional learning translate in the long-term into subject lessons and classroom practices?

(Refer: Integrating Nature Learning to CASEL's SEL Framework)

1.3. Reaching out to Teachers / Educators

With the initial framework and practices developed, we were keen on understanding how it would translate into practice. For this, we launched an online pilot workshop with a goal to engage with a small focus group of teachers / educators, for trialling out the initially developed practices and taking into

consideration their feedback and responses which will influence the future implementation of the programme.

For this purpose, an open call was announced on Nature Classrooms' social media platform, inviting teachers to sign up for the programme. From a total of 24 registrations, 11 teachers were selected who teach in schools that follow different boards of education - Montessori, CBSE, Early Childhood Education, IGCSE, IB; teaching a range of subjects such as language, maths, science, art, and nature education. From the 11 selected teachers, there was active participation from 4-5 teachers on an average per session.

2. ASSESSING REFLECTIONS

Different models of reflections have been adopted to assess participant experiences and key takeaways. These include:

- **Reflective Questions**: which require participants to provide long-form reflective answers to a guided questionnaire. These were conducted at different points during the programme:
    - Pre and post programme
    - Reflections post each session
- **Documenting responses during sessions**: The responses of participants to different prompts and guided practices introduced to them during the session were also recorded.
- **Post-programme reflections**: to understand from participants their key takeaways and plans for inculcating nature-based SEL in their teaching-learning approaches.

3. PROGRAMME STRUCTURE

The programme was divided into 8-sessions spanning across a period of 4-6 weeks.

Session No.	Session Title	Description
1.	**Pre-Session Planning**	An introductory session to informally connect all the participants with each other. Given the participant-centric approach, the goal was to jointly plan the schedule of the programme.

2.	**Introduction to Objectives of the Programme**	This session offered an insight to the participants on the objectives driving the nature-based SEL initiative, and an overall introduction to Nature Classrooms work.
3.	**Identity - Finding Oneness with Nature (Self-Awareness)**	In the first session, the participants were encouraged to explore their perception of self and how it intertwines with their feelings and emotions. This was linked with how they believe nature contributes to their sense of self-awareness.
4.	**Stewardship - Finding Support in Nature (Self-Management)**	Participants explored ways in which nature can support them in managing their emotions.
5.	**Belongingness - Finding the 'US' within Nature (Social Awareness)**	The participants explored how their social and natural surroundings influence their emotions and well-being and vice versa. They worked towards gaining awareness of the social and environmental settings that they are a part of through the lenses of empathy and compassion.
6.	**Collaborations - Finding the Connections with Nature (Relationship Skills)**	Participants unravelled ways to navigate the diverse social and environmental relationships and recognize their interconnections and influence on their overall emotions and well-being. They were encouraged to become aware of the changes occurring in their immediate environment and the subsequent effect on their emotions.
7.	**Reflecting - How can I support Nature? (Responsible Decision Making)**	Participants recognized the influence of their emotions on the choices that they make, and collaboratively understanding how they can nurture abilities that encourage them to make more caring, empathetic, and compassionate decisions towards themselves, the people around them, and the environment

8.	**Closing Discussion - Feedback and Way Forward**	In this session we looked back at our journey through the six sessions, and shared and reflected upon our personal as well as collective takeaways, and the possible way forward.

3.1. Session Structure

As recommended in CASEL's Signature Practices Playbook, every session must include three main elements - welcoming inclusion activities, engaging strategies, and optimistic closure. Using this as a guide each of the session was built on the following structure:

- Checking-In with Our Emotions
- Invitations
- Opening Discussion
- Practice I
- Practice II
- Reflections
- Closing on a positive note
- Takeaway Practice

3.2. General Practices Followed by the Facilitator

- **Transparency:** The purpose, goals, and objectives of the module were elaborately explained to the teachers and educators. They were also briefed about the possible experiences they may undergo when engaging with these practices.
- **Keeping an open space:** The intent of the module is for teachers to experience their emotions and build a relationship with nature at their own pace. The facilitator tried to always let the participants engage with the practices at their own pace. If at any given point, a participant did not wish to engage or be a part of the activity, they were allowed to step away and join back at their comfort.

- **Sharing emotions and experiences:** It is important to keep in mind that all participants may not feel comfortable sharing their feelings and emotions in front of everyone. The practices were designed to be more self-reflective in nature and participants were allowed to share the responses at their comfort.
- **Do not force the journey:** While the facilitator came into the sessions with certain objectives and goals, it was important to remember that everyone goes through their own unique emotional journeys. It's important to allow space for free-flowing interactions, conversations, and experiences that could make this more meaningful for teachers and educators.
- **Regular check-ins are essential:** Space was being created for regular check-ins during the module and every practice. This was done by asking simple questions like 'How does doing this make you feel?' 'how are you feeling today?' 'how does thinking or talking about this make you feel? etc. This also gives the facilitator an insight into how the participants may engage with different aspects of the session.
- **Planning the sessions:** Time was spent with the teachers and educators to create a schedule for the sessions. Based on their convenience and availability, the dates were pre-decided. This gave them the opportunity to be prepared as well.

4. SESSION-WISE OVERVIEW

SESSION 1: Pre-Planning

Objective: An ice-breaker session to get the participants to connect with each other, and to give a glimpse into the journey of the programme going forward.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Introductions: Common Threads: To break the ice, the participants were grouped in breakout rooms, where they were asked to find nature-related common threads that connect all of them. This could be the landscape they come from, nature-culture associations, the flora and fauna around them etc. It was an exciting start as the participants very quickly realised the very interesting commonalities they shared and how nature can connect people across different regions.

Invitations: A set of agreements were put in place that as a group we all agreed to follow in every session going forward. These were decided upon jointly with a goal to create a safe and inclusive space. These included:

- Let's support one another in creating a safe, inclusive and nurturing space.
- What is shared in the circle stays within the circle.
- At each moment do what feels right and comfortable for you.
- Let's share our love for nature in our own unique ways.

These invitations were repeated and agreed to at the start of every session and participants were encouraged to add to it as and when they felt comfortable.

Engaging Strategies

Introduction to Nature Classrooms and the Programme agenda: Following the icebreaker, the group was introduced to Nature Classrooms work and understanding the larger goals of the programme and what they can expect going forward. We also discussed their role in the program and how they can participate in this process.

Pre-programme reflections: The participants were then sent the pre-programme reflections sheet. It primarily aimed at documenting their expectations from this journey. *(Reflections Document)*

Optimistic Closure

Learnings From Nature: To close the session on a positive note, each member was asked to share their key learnings from nature. Some of the reflections that were shared were:

- Resilience
- Interactions in nature are based on mutualistic relationships
- While everyone's journey is unique, the environment soil, nature that we share are all the same
- Nature makes a comeback every time
- Patience
- Teaches us how to trust the process; everything happens in its own time
- Be comfortable where you are at the moment and bloom
- To slow down - processes in nature don't happen overnight
- Nature gives without expecting anything in return

- Each part of nature is doing its own thing
- It always gives us a feeling of awe

Takeaways from the session

Some reflections that emerged at the end of the session:

- Is this program for teachers or children?
- What can we expect through this process?
- Teachers don't have time to engage - how will it be made a part of the system?
- They were glad to have a space to share their experiences

SESSION 2: Introduction to Nature-based SEL

Objective: An introduction to Social-Emotional Learning framework by CASEL and the nature-based SEL Programme developed by Nature Classrooms.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Checking-in with our emotions: The theme of this check-in was 'Emojis.' Participants were asked to select one emoji from a chart displayed, that best represented how they felt that day. Check-ins are very useful in understanding what mindspace the participants are entering the session with. This also tends to influence how they participate in the interactions. And a check-in at the end of every session is a useful tool to gauge how the session may have impacted the participants emotions.

Icebreaker: Creating New Bonds: For the participants to learn more about each other, a series of questions were displayed. Each of them were asked to spend some time reflecting and sharing the responses in an open circle.

- If you could time travel to any moment in the history of this planet, where would that be and why?
- Can you share a moment from your life where you have felt the calmest or most at peace?
- What are the three most essential things in your life?
- What would you say is the best part of being you?

- How would you describe the relationship between you and nature?
- If there is one message you would like to give to your younger self or future self what would that be?

The responses to these questions were also insightful to understand how the participants already connect with nature and what parts of their identity they associate with nature.

Engaging Strategies

Experience Sharing - Expressive Writing Practice: Each of the participants were asked to bring one memorabilia or item that connects them to their favourite place. They were then asked to engage in an 'Expressive Writing' practice where they were asked to write without lifting their pen for 5 minutes, letting their thoughts flow. A series of prompts were projected to guide this process.

- What makes your favourite place so special?
- How does remembering your favourite place make you feel?
- Looking back, what emotions were you experiencing at that moment when you were at your favourite place?
- Can you recollect the happenings around you? - the smells, sounds, any textures, sights etc.
- Is there any particular thing that you deeply connected with while being there? How did it make you feel?
- Has your favourite place undergone any changes since you last visited? How does that make you feel?
- How do you feel right now having revisited that place through your writing?

At the end of the activity the participants were asked to recognize the key emotions they experienced and if they could associate the different factors / interactions that were triggering these different emotions.

Introduction to Nature-Based SEL: Together we broke down how nature learning can be inculcated to different core aspects of the existing SEL framework. We also explored the correlations between nature and mental health, and ways in which we can deepen our connection with nature.

We also collectively reflected on:

- Importance of emotions in education
    - Understanding one's own emotion - also relating to other's emotions - what is our emotional make-up?
    - Going beyond cognitive and intellectual domains - catering to affective domain
    - Holding a place for yourself and children
    - Self-awareness - interpersonal - resolving conflicts
- Management of emotions through nature:
    - Managing emotions through nature
    - Nature walk - engaging our senses
    - Self-awareness - mindfulness
    - Nature has a lot to share
- How can we connect physics or any other subject to SEL?
    - Freeplay activity to learn science
    - Empathy

Goal Setting Exercise: In this exercise, the participants were asked to use the table shown below and explore how they can individually as well as collaboratively develop on three elements - emotions, process of knowledge creation and sharing, and our relationship with nature - such that it caters to their overall personal, social and the environmental wellbeing?

We started with exploring the possible meanings of these different terms. The responses shared were:

- **Personal well being** : How do I feel? How do I manage my emotions?
- **Social well being**: My relationship with others
- **Environmental well being**: nature and me
    - Social well being is a part of this as well - how do I connect with nature through people?
- **Knowledge creation and sharing**: reflect - what I already know / what I want to know
    - Learning will happen any way - how can we bring wonder and awe
    - Let nature and children just be
- **Social:** how do I enrich and learn from you, what do I learn from nature

The following were the responses from some of the participants:

	Personal Well Being	**Social Well being**	**Environmental Well being**
Emotions	To be able to validate, process and stay with my emotions and let them pass.	To be aware of not letting my emotions affect the people around me.	To be mindful of the choices that I make while being in nature.
Knowledge creation and sharing	Observe, understand, and learn how different each living being is and how differently each one will express their emotions	To create awareness on what role nature plays in our wellbeing (Includes social, emotional and physical)	To help children and adults reconnect with nature. To understand the implications of our actions on nature and to be mindful
Relationship with Nature	To spend more time outdoors, go on walks, to learn more about the flora and fauna of my region and understand Simple sustainable living	To engage and connect with people and gain insights from their experiences with nature.	Two quotes I came across recently made me think," We have borrowed our land from our children, let's hand it over to them in better shape". "What is your and your child's relationship with the real world?"

Goal setting exercise undertaken by one of the participants

Optimistic Closure

Appreciation Spree: To close the session, the floor was opened for each of the participants to take turns and appreciate each other, themselves and nature. The idea was to encourage them to listen and embrace appreciations about themselves and also recognize what leaves them feeling positive about this space.

SESSION 3: Identity - Finding Oneness with Nature (Self-Awareness)

Objective: In this session, participants explored their sense of identity and how it intertwines with their environmental identity.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Checking-in with our emotions: The theme of this check-in was 'Colours.' Participants were asked to convey their emotions using colours and reflecting on why they associate a particular colour to a particular emotion.

Opening Discussion: The session began with participants sharing their initial thoughts upon hearing the phrases / words - 'Self-Awareness,' 'Identity,' 'Nature.' Their responses were:

- **Self-awareness**
    - Physically / mentally what triggers certain emotions
    - Connections with my surroundings
    - Being aware of your emotions, habits, surroundings, of other people, and how you respond to others
    - How I respond and react - and its effect on an environment
    - How do little things bother me? How can I do okay by knowing myself more?
    - Bringing awareness to things that we may otherwise not recognize
- **Identity:**
    - Is an outcome of self-awareness
    - Acceptance - establish myself to others
    - Concept of self
    - Interconnection to others
    - Interaction comes into play - I become aware of my place amidst a crowd of people
    - In different situations identity changes
    - Comes from our past experiences - be it in nature, with culture etc.
    - Parents condition our identity - but we grow and evolve to be our own person

Engaging Strategies

How is Self-Awareness being defined?: The participants were then introduced to CASEL's definition for the 'Self-Awareness' competency. We then went on to reflect how nature can be integrated into this larger definition.

- Recognizing one's own emotions and feelings through different nature-based practices.
- Creating an image of oneself - based on different values and beliefs about ourselves and our surroundings.
- Identifying different external factors that may influence our sense of self - social, cultural, historical, and environmental identity.

Art and Self-Exploration: This consisted of a series of short practices and prompts that encouraged the participants to introspect and learn more about themselves through art. The participants began by visualising their perception of self. They were then asked to visualise emotions - what could a particular emotion look like? They went on to explore different aspects of their daily lives, their dreams, favourite place, larger interactions with everything around them that contribute to their perception of themselves.

Exploring our Environmental Identities: Our relationship with the environment can deeply influence our sense of self, our social role and how we and those around us perceive our identity. Through this activity the aim was to explore how our interactions with nature are intertwined with our self-awareness, our emotions and how we connect with nature.

The participants were asked to draw a large tree. Each part of the tree was representative of one aspect of their identity. The roots represented their memories, the trunk was their values, branches symbolised support systems and the leaves, flowers and fruits were representative of change. Using a series of prompts the participants were encouraged to piece together their environmental identity.

Optimistic Closure

The session ended with rechecking-in of our emotions, and how did this session leave us feeling about ourselves and our connection with and place within nature?

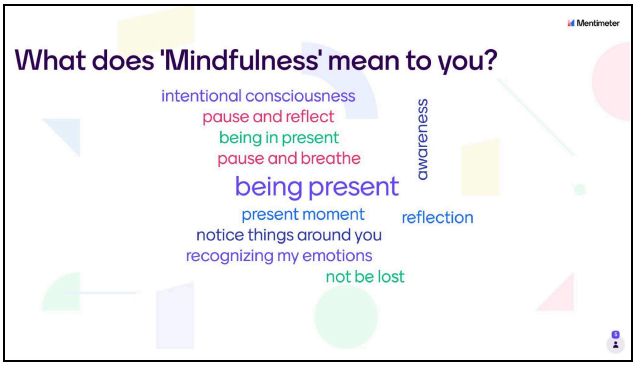
SESSION 4: Stewardship - Finding Support in Nature (Self-Management)

Objective: To explore ways in which nature can support them in managing their emotions.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Checking-in with our emotions: The theme of this check-in was 'Expressions.' Participants were asked to convey through facial expressions how they were feeling at the start of the session.

Opening Discussion: Using the 'Menti' tool the participants shared what the following words / phrases meant to them:



Engaging Strategies

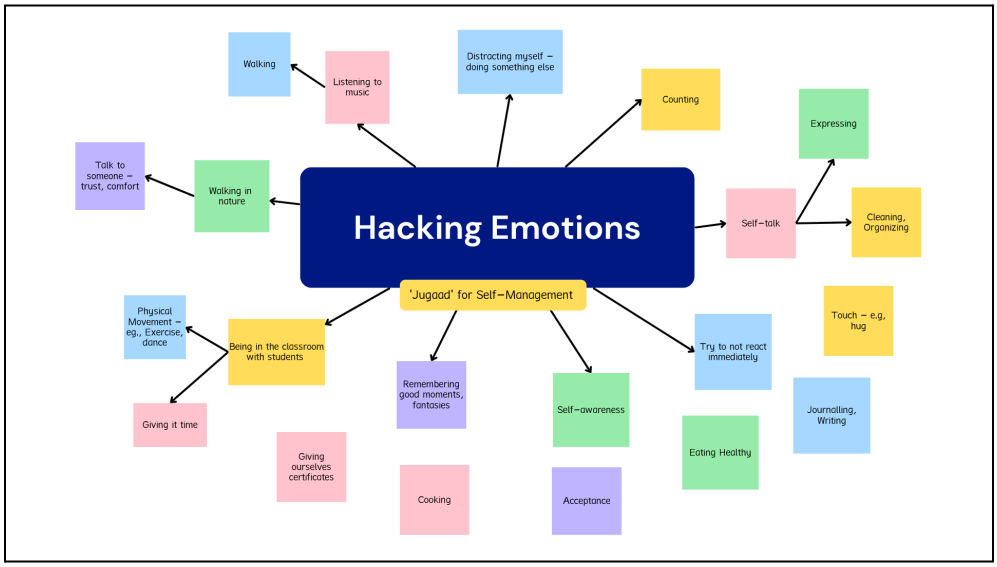
How is Self-Management being defined?: The participants were then introduced to CASEL's definition for 'Self-Managemen,' They were also introduced to Plutchik's Wheel of Emotions. We then went on to reflect how nature can be integrated into this larger definition.

- Recognizing how emotions affect our interactions in different social and environmental settings
- Deepening the connection with nature by exploring nature-related practices for managing emotions.

Putting Our Emotions into Words (Affect Labelling): Using the wheel of emotions as a guide, participants were asked to pen down any interaction or incident that particularly stood out for them that week. They were then encouraged to:

- Recognize and label the emotions that surfaced during the particular engagement
- Rewrite the experience then using the emotions they have listed, trying to also become aware about how these emotions made them express or react?
- Reflect if they always expressed or engaged with this particular emotion(s) in the same way? If not, what are the other ways in which they may have engaged with this emotion?

What's Your Hack?: In this activity the participants were asked to share their strategies for managing their emotions.



The responses were diverse, with a few participants sharing how walking in nature or interacting with plants and animals supports them in emotional management. They also expressed how this exercise gave them new ideas to manage their emotions.

Optimistic Closure

Observing Nature: Research indicates that simply tuning in and noticing good things in urban nature led to significant and sustained improvements in people's mental health - with links to improved satisfaction, reduced anxiety and increased happiness. At the end of the session, the participants were asked to observe their surroundings through a series of guided prompts.

SESSION 5: Belonging - Finding the 'US' in Nature (Social Awareness)

Objective: To explore how the participant's social and natural surroundings influence their emotions and well-being and vice versa.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Checking-in with our emotions: The theme of this check-in was 'Music.' Participants were asked to share how they felt via any song or music or sounds from nature that they felt best represented their emotions in that moment.

Showcase! A virtual tour of your neighbourhood: Prior to the session the participants were asked to bring in one element from their surrounding nature that best represented their neighbourhood. During the session, each of the participants were asked to do a showcase and share - why did they choose that particular item to represent their neighbourhood? In the process of searching did they discover anything new about the nature around them? How does this contribute to their connection with their surrounding spaces?

Engaging Strategies

Opening Discussion: The participants were posed with a question - Does our social and environmental surroundings influence us? And if so in what ways? Some of the key points that came out of this discussion were:

- Feeling of fitting in - sense of acceptance, belonging
- Seeking connections
- Social Beings
- Learning new things
- Sense of freedom and safety
- Finding our community
- Gives energy to pursue other things
- Being myself in a community
- Sense of comfort
- "Unconditional" acceptance
- People or spaces we resonate with
- Accountability - towards nature
- Security from nature

How is Social Awareness being defined?: The participants were then introduced to CASEL's definition for the 'Social Awareness' competency. We then went on to reflect how nature can be integrated into this larger definition.

- Recognizing our social and environmental identity and the interconnections.
- Understanding the characteristics of the community and environment which gives us our sense of belonging.
- Understanding how one's own emotions are influenced by social and environmental interactions
- Identifying how social and environmental interactions can influence our emotions.

Mapping Our Neighbourhood: Through this activity participants were asked to draw out the map of their neighbourhood. Then with help of guiding prompts they were asked to mark different spaces using different colours that represented how they felt. Some of these prompts included - marking their favourite places they regularly visit, any water bodies that are around them, any prominent trees and

plants in their neighbourhood, places where they source their food and ingredients from, places where they have spotted birds, insects and other animals etc, any particular sounds and smells that define their community, etc. Once marked they were asked to reflect:

- Can you recollect any changes in particular that have occurred in your neighbourhood, maybe over the past few years? Draw or mark those areas? How did that make you feel?
- How are the different spaces in your neighbourhood influencing your sense of identity?
- If you were to remove the following elements from your community, what would or would not change? How would it change the interconnectedness? And how would that make you feel?
- How is the place where you lived as a child different from where you live now? What are the factors that make it different?
- What importance do these different spaces hold in your lives?
- Are there any parts or places of your neighbourhood you would like to connect with more deeply?

The goal of the activity was for them to gain awareness of the subtle connections they may have with their neighbourhood and how it contributes to who they are. Also to recognize and connect with nature in their immediate surrounding.

Optimistic Closure

Spin-A-Story: Working together, the group was to develop a story where each person adds one line such that together they create a story that reflects their values, beliefs, knowledge, etc. Before starting they were collectively asked to decide the theme, characters, age group and the key message they would like to convey. By the end of the story, they reflected back on whether the story achieved their initial goal.

When I Feel Happy I...?: To end the session on a positive thought each participant was asked to share one thing they do when they feel the most happy.

SESSION 6: Collaborations - Finding Our Connections With Nature (Relationship Skills)

Objective: Participants map out their diverse social and environmental relationships and recognize their interconnections and the influence on their overall emotions and well-being.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Story Time - The Fig and Fig Wasp Story: The session began with a read-aloud of the Fig and Fig Wasp story. Sharing their reflections from the story:

- Commitment
- Let-go and acceptance
- Selflessness, forgiveness
- Compatibility
- Growing together
- Difficult - investing time and energy
- Intentionality
- Partnership
- Families - duty

Engaging Strategies

How are Relationship Skills being defined?: The participants were then introduced to CASEL's definition for 'Relationship Skills.' We then went on to reflect how nature can be integrated into this larger definition.

- Recognizing the integral network of relationships - at a personal, social and environmental level.
- Exploring the influence of these relationships on our identities and emotions.
- Acknowledging the importance of these relationships in our lives and understanding how different relationships can be nurtured differently.
- Exploring how our social relationships influence our connection and relationship with nature and vice versa.

Mapping Our Social and Environmental Relationships: For this practice, a series of guiding prompts were displayed on the screen. Participants were asked to spend some time with each prompt and write down the first person, place, being etc. that comes to their mind. This activity was inspired from the '**SEL Shala' course organised by ApniShala**. Examples of some prompts that were shared were:

- Add names of people in your current life who you think you like, care about and/or appreciate.
- Think about people who offered you new and diverse perspectives when you were not able to see it for yourself.
- Think about people who you see as role models for gender equality, social justice, community leadership, etc.
- How would you define your present relationship with nature?
- Write about a moment where you have felt cared by nature.
- Have you ever felt disconnected from nature? If so, when and how?
- What is your ideal relationship? Are you there yet?
- What is the one thing you would like to thank nature for? Etc.

From the activity the key takeaways that were shared by the participants included:

- With simpler relationships the answers came more quickly to the mind
- Recognition of so many relationships and its value, which we otherwise may overlook
- The question about 'hurting nature' has so many more responses
- Nature has a constant presence
- Nature takes a back seat but its still there
- Compassion from nature - it is going to be there no matter what we do
- No schedule when it comes to nature and the relationship we have with it
- Prioritising convenience
- Nature is also not demanding

Optimistic Closure

An Interview with Nature: The participants were split into pairs and put in two breakout rooms. Here they were asked to select any one being in nature, except humans. Using the prompts they were encouraged to step into the shoes of that being and explore what it would like to be them. Some of the prompts shared were:

- What does a day in their life look like?
- What kind of social and environmental interactions are they engaging in?
- What emotions do they encounter throughout the day?
- What do their family lives look like? What exchanges and experiences would they be having?
- How do they feel about us humans? What kind of interactions do they have with humans?

The activity got both the pairs excited with each group sharing playing out the role of their chosen being:

- **Group 1: Stray Cat**
    - Need for security, love, moving around - isn't very structured
    - Loves exploring, is in search for security and food
    - Really good observer
    - Forms alliance - with other cats and humans
    - Adapted to city life
    - Emotions - contentment, anxiety
- **Group 2: Old Tree**
    - Silent spectator, supports life
    - Needs are very simple
    - Not dependent on humans
    - Self-reliant
    - How insignificant and menial we are in front of the tree
    - Trees follow live and let live philosophy

SESSION 7: Reflections - How Can I Support Nature? (Decision-Making)

Objective: Recognizing the influence of emotions on the choices that we make, and collaboratively work towards nurturing abilities that encourage more caring, empathetic, and compassionate decisions towards ourselves and nature.

Welcoming Inclusion Activities

Opening Discussion: How many decisions do we make in a day? We opened the session with participants listing out all the decisions that they take in one day. They were surprised to hear that every individual takes over 35,000 decisions every day.

What is a decision then?

- Majority of me being in concurrence with what I am thinking and going to do
- Choosing from the alternatives
- Something that adds certainty to my routine / day
- Best thing to do in that moment (can change later) [‘Best’ - that which helps me prioritise or plan things better / brings peace of mind]
- Yes / No (can be simple or complex)
- Deeply ingrained - sometimes automatic / effortless
- Trade-offs

Engaging Strategies

Evaluating Our Decisions: The participants were asked to go back to the decisions that they had listed out. They were then asked to rate their decision from a scale of 1 to 5 (1 being not good to 5 being excellent) based on how it contributes to three key parameters - personal well being, social well being and environmental well being. Then using some guiding prompts they shared their reflections from engaging with this process:

- **How does rating your decision make you feel?**
    - Overthinking - justification
    - Not actively thought about environment factors so far
    - Shows how I prioritise my decisions
    - Many Overlaps
    - Perspective - which are the things that are important - many a times we feel we are not doing enough - but this helps reflect

- **What criteria did you assign for your ratings?**
    - Looking at personal needs, entertainment, nourishment, safety
    - To get things done / accomplishing things
    - Mixture of both
- **What values inform your decisions?**
    - Integrity, self-respect, honesty, creating safe-spaces, choosing kindness, empathy, compassion, consideration, punctuality, care, respecting my work, what I offer to the community, organised, discipline
    - Decision as an educator
- **Upon doing this evaluation, is there anything you would like to change?**
    - Being transparent in conversations
    - Being kind to ourselves / empathy towards ourselves and nature
    - Try to consider environment's well being wherever possible
    - More sharing of responsibilities

How is Responsible Decision Making being defined?: The participants were then introduced to CASEL's definition for 'Responsible Decision Making' competency. We then went on to reflect how nature can be integrated into this larger definition.

- Gaining awareness about the impact of our choices on self, the society and the environment.
- Re-evaluating the ways in which we make decisions in our day-to-day lives such that it positively impacts personal, social and environmental well-being

Discussion: What Is Your Decision-Making Process?

- Start with a question - what is it I am trying to do or a decision that needs to be made?
- Looking at the alternatives / options
- Thinking about parameters of urgency and importance - priority (not all things can be met in one decision)
- Things that may help in the longer run - planning ahead
- Identify noise / external factors that are beyond my control - focus on my sphere of control.
- Practical aspects - how practical the idea is?
- Knowing the action items - next steps

- Consequences

Decision Quality: The participants were then introduced to some theories and research that exist around what makes for a quality decision.

Case Study: The following hypothetical study was then read out to the participants.

> *You are a primary school teacher working in (a school board of your choice). You are on a nature excursion trip with the students of your grade, along with your colleague. During the excursion, one of the students accidently falls and gets injured. You and your colleague, while taking care of all the other students, are also trying hard to get this student to the nearest hospital. The student gets timely admitted to the hospital.*
>
> *Upon returning to the school you are faced with a range of questions, interactions and decisions:*
>
> - *The parents of the injured child approach you and your colleague carrying their anger and sorrows.*
> - *You are bombarded with questions and concerns, making you repeatedly recall the incident*
> - *Your students, disturbed by this incident, haven't had the opportunity yet to process the entire situation*
> - *The school administration ban any further nature excursions or practical sessions for EVS*
> - *You are expected to resume classes-as-usual from the very next day*

After spending some time reflecting they were encouraged to journal their responses to the following prompts:

- What are the series of decisions that you would have had to make through the course of this entire incident?
- What are some ways in which you will address and engage with the different situations in front of you?
- Explore how this would personally affect your mental well-being?
- How would you take care of yourself while taking up the different roles and responsibilities?
- How do you see yourself overall addressing personal, social and environmental wellbeing? What are the gains, trade-offs and costs?

- How does this incident challenge your values?

Optimistic Closure

Give A Hug!: To close the final session, each participant was encouraged to say one thing that they discovered something about themselves through this journey that fills them with pride and joy, and then give themselves the tightest hug!

SESSION 8: Closing Session: Reflections

Objective: We look back at our journey through the six sessions, and share and reflect upon our personal as well as collective takeaways, and the possible way forward

Agenda and Key Outcomes:

The goal of this session was to open the floor for reflections and feedback from the participants. To understand what their key takeaways were, some highlights from this experience, anything new that they may have encountered, and if it has or hasn't contributed to how they perceive and connect with nature. And finally, how do they see such a programme being taken forward to more teachers and educators.

Key Reflections Shared:

- The programme created a space where everyone listens, opens up and expresses
- Thoughtful
- It has the potential to address how teachers emotions impacts students
- Encouraged us to appreciate all the little things around us - a big takeaway
- Understand Socio-emotional learning as being in touch with things we may not know about
- Created a safe sense of community
- Giving agency
- Let teachers facilitate some parts
- **Challenges and gaps:**
    - How would we integrate this program?

        - Should not be an added burden for teachers
    - If it takes extra time there maybe hesitation
    - Nature needs to be more deeply integrated into the 'Decision-Making' competency
    - Increasing the total number of sessions and instead reducing the duration of each session. And each practice should be dedicated more time.
    - Given the hierarchical structures in the system, not sure about openness to this idea
    - It threatens some parts of the system - we need to more strongly reinforce well being of teachers

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CHALLENGES AND LIMITATIONS

- Since the sessions were being conducted online, it was difficult to control the setting of the space and to also develop practices that are more contextual to the surroundings.
- Given the short duration, it was difficult to deeply engage in all the practices.
- With respect to reflections, given that the process of filling up essay-based questionnaires is time consuming, most participants were not actively engaging in writing their responses. This limited the scope of assessing the reflections of all the participants.
- In online sessions it is also difficult to gauge the real experiences of the participant. It also becomes challenging to actively inculcate nature within the practices.

WAY FORWARD

Building up on the experience and feedback gained from the pilot workshop, going forward our plan with this initiative would be to:

- Organising another online or hybrid version of the programme
- Connecting with existing organisations that are working in the SEL space, and pitching the inclusion of nature learning into their framework and practices.
- Developing short guides and resources that teachers and educators can independently use to inculcate nature-based SEL in their teaching-learning practices.

ANNEXURE: RESPONSES TO REFLECTION QUESTIONNAIRE

A. Pre-Program Reflections

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
What relationship would you say you share with your emotions presently?	Not very pleasant, I guess. I think I'm too judgemental about myself.	I validate and stay with my emotions and observe them. I try to process them instead of distracting myself.	I have a close relationship with my emotions. I am very sensitive to my own emotions as well as those of others, it has always been that way. I'm only now learning how to wield this as a strength, especially in the classroom, with my students, with myself, and my loved ones. For most of my life it has felt like a weakness, however, now I realize it adds a depth and richness to my experience, and my ability to connect with others where they are.	Quite aware of emotions of self. Most often my emotions link to specific instances or surroundings. Sometimes it is easy to regulate my feelings and get back into the moment while at other moments it takes longer to pass through those.	Well, I have a deep relationship with my emotions. Whatever emotions I go through, I feel them with high intensity. Sometimes I don't understand why they are there. I am now learning to manage my emotions and seeing them without judging them.
How often do you check-in with yourselves in a week, as to how you are feeling?	Learning to do it regularly. Off and on	I reflect quite often and do check with myself on most days. I try to let go of the things which are not under my control. On some days I fail though.	Very often. My internal experience of life is just as vivid, if not more, than my outer experience. The emotions I have, the connections my mind makes, the patterns I recognise are all very interesting parts of	Every morning of the week.	At least once a day. I realized when I check how I am feeling consciously then I see it from a third person's perspective and do not react to it.

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
			my internal experience of life. I check in once a day generally, and I have micro check ins with myself whenever I need them		
Can you recognize the different emotions you have experienced?	Yes, I think I can	Yes.	I can, generally speaking. Sometimes, it might be harder, so I use other techniques to help me.	Yes, usually I am able to identify how I am feeling and why.	Not always but yes most of the time. What I don't know mostly is why do I feel the way I do? Emotions tell us a lot about ourselves.
What are some ways in which you manage your diverse emotions?	Thinking, overthinking, talking about it to my husband	I usually have the habit of writing down quotes and dialogues which are relatable and resonate with me from books or any series that I have watched. I go back and read them. Cleaning and organizing my surroundings help me manage my emotions and a warm shower. I also talk to my close friends if I'm having a bad day in particular and I'm unable to	Continuing from the previous question - I have a strong relationship with spirituality, and energy-based practices. I have completed my 3rd degree in Reiki. So, if I need a little help with my feelings, I usually do a bit of self-reiki, sometimes some form of meditation (maybe a walking meditation - sitting still is hard for me with my ADHD), or EFT helps a lot too.	Talk to people I trust and self-introspect. Try to look at the positive side of things. If still unable to overcome those then I take time and let my emotions flow.	I talked to a loved one, went for a walk, watched something, listened to music, thought about something else, taking my anger out. But sometimes none of them work.

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
		manage my emotions on my own			
How would you define your present relationship with nature?	Missing walks/trails in a forest	Still discovering and exploring my relationship with nature. Being in nature and spending time outdoors, going on walks brings a sense of calm and peace which helps me regulate my emotions	I feel deeply connected to nature, its presence is enough to soothe me and remind me of what's 'real' in life - trees, grass, our loved ones, spending time with them, breathing deeply and fully. As opposed to zoom meetings, screens, notifications, and other junk that tends to clutter my mind.	Very close, healing, giving, rejuvenating, nurturing.	I love nature a lot. Nature heals me and keeps me grounded. I have this urge to be in nature now.
What do the terms 'nature learning' and 'emotional learning' mean to you?	Nature learning to me is about exploring all the wonderful things and finding a connection with them. Like I said yesterday, going to a forest feels like coming home. It is very soothing and a meditative experience for me. I remember reading about something called Shinrin Yoku, the Japanese word for forest bathing and I think I have experienced it every single time how calming it is for me.	The ability to be in a space, assimilate what it has to offer, enjoy the beauty of the present, being really present, mindful and aware of your space, trusting the process of nature and letting go of things which are not under one's control.	Learning how to identify, manage, and regulate our emotions, connect with others, and maintain social relationships using nature as a medium and guide.	Nature Learning - learning from the very natural way of things, people, environment. Emotional learning - Learning about self-emotions, managing them, interpersonal emotions.	Nature learning is the one which happens in nature or with nature. Emotional learning where we learn how to work with our emotions.

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
	Emotional learning for me is about figuring out about my own self, who I am and how that knowledge about myself can help me in building better connections with those around me. On a personal level also I have come to realize its importance a lot in the last three four years but as a teacher also I realize how important it is for a teacher to learn how to be there for the young people you meet. There are so many people who need someone to listen to. Adolescence can be a lonely and challenging period. I remember how difficult it was for me and how that period of my life, the emotions and Loneliness I felt then, and low self-esteem continue to affect me even today.				
As a teacher / educator, what role	It directly has an impact on the quality of classes/ interactions	Personally, I believe that emotions are what makes us	I work with students from grades 1 to 8, and I find that I connect best with students	Very important. I need to connect with the emotions of my learners, their	The work that I do has everything to do with connections. And

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
does emotions play in the work you do?		human. It connects us to each other and builds an understanding of everything around us. Without emotions we would be like machines. As an educator, emotions play a huge role in the work that I do. It helps me connect with my children. I facilitate and cater to the needs of very young children (20 months to 6 /7 years). My role is to positively and sensitively help my children in their transitions from Home to School environment, to build the trust so that they feel safe and belonged. To provide a space where they can be who they are without any prejudices, to hold space for them in the	when I am able to meet them halfway. This means if I'm conducting an interactive class, and one of my students tells me not feeling so good, I can empathize with that and offer them an alternate way of participating with the class which might be less social. It also means I'm aware of how my emotions might affect them, on days I don't feel too good, I make sure to be a little extra kind with them as well as myself, and give them the benefit of the doubt if needed, or defer any decisions (about marks, assignments, indiscipline) to the next day where I am feeling more like myself so I can try to act according to my values as much as possible.	interest, curiosity, boredom, pace of absorption to connect with them for exchange of knowledge. Their emotional readiness allows them to be open to learning and they cannot be pushed into it. Giving their emotions time and space to learn naturally by observing and exploring	emotions are an integral part of us hence they affect the connection or relationships because they affect you.

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
		time of chaos, to provide a scaffolding when they have difficulties in understanding and learning, to give them the words to express themselves, to be patient and observe them in order to understand their developmental needs which includes physical, mental, social and emotional needs. As an individual, I strongly believe that whether it is children or adults, both will thrive and flourish in an environment where an individual is respected, accepted for who they are without any judgment and where they have the opportunity to learn together, grow together and contribute together.			

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2	TEACHER 3	TEACHER 4	TEACHER 5
Do you incorporate nature learning and emotional learning in your teaching-learning approaches? If yes, in what ways do you do the same?	In higher classes we do occasionally have conversations about emotions, sometimes with the help of a story or sometimes Just discussion. Though these conversations are not as often as I would like them to be. I do feel I should be better equipped to have these conversations with young adults		Yes, I take my students into the open lawns we have on campus for classes, when the weather is good. I try to incorporate physical movement, it helps with students of all ages to release some energy, and it's fun to be outside under the sun rather than in a class all day, even for me.	Letting learning take place naturally without following a set process.	Nature learning: I want to but I have not been able to. I am not sure what emotional learning is but i pay a lot of attention on student's emotions as I talk to them about it and listen to them. I also feel that the spaces should be given to them to learn to understand their emotions and help them to discover ways to deal with their emotions.
What are your key expectations from this program?	Still curious what it is going to be like. Looking forward to learning anything that is about nature or about emotional well-being	I'm Looking forward to spending my time with each one of you and learning and taking it forward in my journey.	● Understanding ways of managing my stress and emotions as a teacher ● Meeting like-minded educators who love nature, understand the importance of one's emotions, and care for the students the way I do ● Building and nurturing this little community of educators	Understand the program and the details of it. I have a conviction that such a program will really help the teachers and their students	To understand more about socio-emotional aspects of learning. To understand more about my challenges and how to deal with them. To find tools for my social emotional learning for myself and students. To learn from others in the group.

A. Reflections from Session conducted on Self-Awareness (Finding Oneness with Nature)

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1	TEACHER 2
What were your expectations from this session, prior to joining?	I had no expectations, honestly. However, the previous sessions were very interesting so I knew this one would be too.	I wasn't very sure about joining this session as I was traveling so my only expectation was that I be allowed to join on listening mode so I am very happy that I could attend it. I have been on this journey of self exploration and knowing myself since the last 5 to 6 years. There is a lot that I have unlearned to be a better person. I think a lot of growth has happened in the last 5 years but I think it is just the beginning and I am yet to learn so much more. But for starters one thing I want to learn is how to not beat myself up and also not let others affect me so much. So, I was hoping to hear something connected with that.
How was the experience for you, personally, in this session? And as a teacher?	Well, the session started off with us drawing and adding colours as per the prompts that were given. It was extremely helpful in recognizing how we see certain aspects of ourselves and our emotions.	I attended it while traveling but I still enjoyed every bit of it. While attending these two sessions I was thinking how wonderful it would be if we had such spaces to share even at our workplace. I am sure that all the work places will have some challenges and difficult people but I wish there was some support system everywhere. As teachers deal with young people, I think it is very important that we know who we are to be able to be there for our students. I think there are not enough safe spaces for teachers to be vulnerable. We are required to 'know it all' but that puts a lot of pressure. The session helped me see how we all are flawed humans with our own concerns on which we all are working and it is important to remember that we are a work in progress.

What were your key learnings from this session? How did these learnings make you feel?	I counted all of my blessings in this particular exercise.	I have been reading about the importance of mindfulness and self-awareness and like I said in the session, I tend to be very harsh with myself. While attending the session and hearing others talk, I realized how it is difficult for everyone and we all are looking for answers, ways to deal with things that are difficult for us. I think the practice of pausing and reflecting is very important to have a better perspective about things.
Do you think nature can contribute to our sense of self-awareness? If so, how?	Absolutely. There's so much you can learn from nature. If you observe it and spend some time outdoors, it has such wisdom that every tiny detail can teach you so much about life.	I think in the last five - years nature has played a key role in my life in bringing awareness about what I want from life and what my strengths are.
From the practices, what linkages do you draw between your personal sense of self-awareness and environmental identity?		Everything that we do, every choice that we make has consequences on the world around us. If I am more conscious about my choices maybe wherever I am there can be at least a little difference. Some people say individual actions don't account for much but I have learnt that they do.
Any other feedback / suggestions / comments - regarding session content, facilitator, overall interactions etc.		The conversations in the sessions are enriching. I am just happy I happened to see the post about these sessions and found courage to fill the form.

B. Reflections from Session conducted on Self-Management (Finding Support in Nature)

QUESTIONS	TEACHER 1
What were your expectations from this session, prior to joining?	I was hoping to explore some strategies that would help me in not giving too much attention to what others say and find strength in being true to myself. And the session did meet my expectations. It was very helpful.
How was the experience for you, personally, in this session? And as a teacher?	I really enjoyed the session. It was meditative.
What were your key learnings from this session? How did these learnings make you feel?	It made me feel light and wonderful about myself. I learnt so many different ways in which I can cope with stress. Plus, I also realized that some of the practices that I already do are useful as well. I used to think I don't put effort on my own to resolve things but I realized that there are certain things that I do but don't acknowledge my effort.
What meaning and value do you associate with self-management, post the session? And how do you see yourself practicing it in your everyday life?	I have been wanting to start journaling but haven't really started it. The guided activity helped me a lot in doing it meaningfully. The tools were useful and maybe I will use them for myself. NVC is also something which has been very helpful in understanding myself and people around me. I came across it only two years back and I think it will take a while to internalize it.
Do you think nature can support us in managing our emotions? If yes or no, how?	Yes, it can. This question reminds me of 'Shinrin Yoku'- forest bathing. Just being surrounded by trees makes me feel nice. Hugging a tree makes one feel even better. In all, noticing birds, insects, squirrels it just helps me remember how wonderful the world is. It acts as an anchor sometimes when I feel lost.
Any other feedback / suggestions / comments - regarding session content, facilitator, overall interactions etc.	The third and the fourth sessions were lovely. Just want to express gratitude to the facilitator for creating this space and being kind and patient with us. Her and the participants enthusiasm is contagious. Very happy to be a part of this group.